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Three Medieval Rhetorical Arts, [Principles of Letter Writing; New Poetics; Form of Preaching] by James J. Murphy

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detailed research has been published since it was done which detracts from its usefulness today.

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Three Medieval Rhetorical Arts, [Principles of Letter Writing; New Poetics; Form of Preaching]. James J. Murphy, ed. Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1971.

Jerry Murphy, already established in the field of medieval rhetoric, has contributed a major work to the field--and lengthened his own professional shadow--by providing for the first time in English three medieval theories of rhetoric translated from Latin. The first, translation by Murphy himself, handles the art of letter-writing. The second, translated by Jane Baltzell Kopp, provides a view of the "new poetics." The third is a translation of a preaching tract. Two short appendices and a selected bibliography conclude the book.

With the large gap in medieval rhetorical literature--a gap which sorely cries for workers who can handle the materials--one might argue that we should declare a moratorium on the writing of "Fundamentals of . . ." or "Elements of . . ." either in spoken or written discourse, and that we should devote the next half-dozen years to translating, editing, and critically commenting upon a fair sized mountain of materials too long neglected. Surely we would not suffer greatly with such a vacation from elementary treatises.

The three bodies of principles here came from the pen of (perhaps) as many nationalities (Italian, English and French[?]), over an equal number of centuries (12th, 13th, and 14th) and a similar number of occupations: grammarian, theologian, and "dictator" (letter-writer).

The art of letter writing developed in the eleventh century as an administrative answer to communication problems in official documents. Designed to provide models for letters and memoranda in an age of considerable forensic sterility, the art often subordinated virtually all rhetoric to writing. Not until the renaissance does rhetoric recover some of its lost gusto of an earlier age. Not surprising then, an anonymous twelfth century Bologna author in the "Principles of Letter Writing" (Rationes dictandi) draws many parallels from oral communication and applies them to written discourse: the introduction of the letter, the parts (5) developed in some detail, style, protocol, etc. But his ambiguously defined "letter," a crucial item in his argument ("a suitable arrangement of words set forth to express the intended meaning of its sender," III), sounds suspiciously like some twentieth century textbooks defining "speech": so inclusive and generalized as to demand immediate exceptions.

The second of the three essays, Geoffrey of Vinsauf's "New Poetics" (Poetria Nova), reveals a thirteenth century treatise on poetic theory. Dedicated to Pope Innocent III (1198-1216), it conceives of poetry as a species of eloquence, and urges the aspiring writer to "let not the hand rush to the pen," since thoughts must be first in the mind and second in words. The beginning should, like a courteous servant, welcome the matter; the middle, like a conscientious host, provide gracious hospitality; and the end, like the herald at a race's conclusion, dismiss the matter with respect.

This Englishman's writing is rich in imagery, apt phrases, and examples, as well as abundantly illustrated with the normal figures one finds in ancient and medieval literature. One expects to find good stylistic advice re, adaptation to the situation, use of good sense, skill, and the like, and he does find it.

Toward the close Geoffrey shifts abruptly from poetry to oral discourse with some common observations on how to proceed with the voice, speaker's appearance, and gestures.

Centuries before S.S. Curry and the "think the thought" school of expression, Geoffrey writes, "the inner and outer man are identically moved," feel and act the same way!

The last tractate, "Form of Preaching" (*Forma praedicandi*), by the fourteenth century Robert of Basevorn is the longest of the three (about equal to the total of the other two), and the one most typically scholastic in tone and matter, with its detailed analyses, distinctions, divisions, catalogues of parts, etc. Here and there taking a theme, the author spins these off in a variety of ways. All are prescriptively treated within the scope of fifty chapters. As with other, though later, renaissance writers, he spends much time on the calling of the preacher, his personal requirements, and knowledge level, though without neglecting the theory and practice of the pulpit. He gives some attention to winning the audience, but the treatment is largely desultory.

Since the Universities of Paris and Oxford were the two leading university educational centers, the author treats somewhat closely, though not always clearly, the way each institution handles the subject of preaching. In the end their respective approaches seem analogous to the debate between the Theodoreans and Apollodoreans in the ancient world: important to those involved, but only remotely interesting even to later scholars.

At the same time, certain shortcomings obtain in the book. Generally, one might wish for more critical introductory essays for each study, though Murphy's is the best of the three. The same weakness holds for the critical apparatus and discussion of the manuscript traditions for each. Krul, particularly, is vulnerable in failing to track down the 300 or more quotations used in his text. A few, very few, he has noted.

Names of two unknown men crop up, one ("William," p. 108) in the Kopp work, the other ("Guido," ;. 144) in Krul's. I would suggest William I, King of Scotland, whom history paints as a protector of the commoners and a great man, as a more likely candidate than either she suggests. "Guido," praised as a preacher "in former times," Krul suggests could have been Guido D'Arezzo, the reformer of musical theory and scales. Hardly, and primarily because he had nothing to do, so far as I know, with preaching. More likely: Guido D'Cortona (d. 1245 or 1250), the Franciscan monk and friend of Francis of Assisi, or perhaps Guido D'Viena (Pope, 1119-24) whom Migne (*Patrol. Lat.*, CLXIII, 1073-83) saw important enough to include four of his sermons.

Several typos or grammatical oddities slipped through the galley stage: Preface (p. vii, "The three arts also a considerable span of time . . .;" p. xiii, Bede's work on style is initially misspelled [ftn. 17]; and p. xvi, a period should follow 1100's; p. 42 (ftn. 23, "Poetra"); p. 49, "suppose;" p. 87, "speech," p. 99, "rich is the man for whom what he has enough;" p. 145, "merely;" and p. 171, "lif."

Finally, in both the Murphy and Krul studies the translators omitted (with no explanation) part of their essays--as if they tired of the job. Should we not expect the works in their entirety?

Despite some misgivings at what one reads, we have here important additions to the all too meagre literature of the middle ages.

But now I should follow the advice of Geoffrey to the poets: "control the detail and conserve the meaning." Quit!

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A QUERY

Mostly we find discussions of argument centering on discussions of effective or ineffective, good or bad, correct or incorrect argument. But just when is an argument unfair? Is the charge that one is being unfair in any conceivable way related to the form of one's argument? What norms are being appealed to in such a charge? Is it that the argument is simply ad hominem?

--editor--